Local Privacy Notice

Information for parents, carers, and teachers

Investigating Children's Agency when Learning with AI

1. Introduction

The UCL Knowledge Lab ("we", "us" or "our") respects your privacy and is committed to protecting your personal data. This notice explains how we use information about young people taking part in the CHAILD agency evaluation study, their parents or carers, and teachers who take part in interviews or help with recruitment.

We will invite up to 25 young people aged 13–17 to use our research chatbot for learning at home and/or school for about five weeks. The study includes questionnaires, weekly conversations with researchers, a closing interview, and records of app use. Parents/carers and teachers will also be invited to individual interviews, with separate consent for their participation.

Please read this notice alongside the study information sheets and the children's easy-read notice. It supplements the UCL General Research Participant Privacy Notice.

We keep this Privacy Notice under regular review. It was last updated on 14 October 2026.

2. About us

The UCL Knowledge Lab is part of the UCL Institute of Education at University College London (UCL). We are working with the Oxford Child-Centred AI Design Lab in the University of Oxford's Department of Computer Science. The study is part of the UKRI-funded CHAILD programme (MR/Z505882/1).

UCL, a company incorporated by Royal Charter (number RC 000631), is the entity that determines how and why your personal data is processed. The University of Oxford collaborates under a data sharing agreement defining the institutions' responsibilities. This means that UCL and The University of Oxford are joint "controllers" of your personal data for the purposes of data protection law.

3. Personal data that we collect about you

Personal data, or personal information, means any information about an individual from which that person can be identified. It does not include data where the identity has been removed (anonymous data).

We may collect, use, store and transfer different kinds of personal data about you. This may include:

- **Study administration:** names, contact details, school and year group, consent and assent forms, signatures, dates and consent records; arrangements for interviews; and withdrawal requests and confirmations. School and youth organisation contacts are used for recruitment and coordination.

- **Questionnaires and check-ins:** young people's age, year group, gender, previous AI experience, attitudes, learning choices, engagement and wellbeing responses.
- **Interviews and research notes:** audio recordings, transcripts, and researchers' notes about young people's learning and experiences, as well as parents' and teachers' views. Interviews will be recorded using UCL Microsoft Teams services.
- **App activity and content:** study accounts, chat messages and AI replies, conversation goals and reflections, uploaded files and images, feedback, clicks and features used, and the times, duration and frequency of use. Research logs can contain message content, document extracts, and copies of uploaded media.
- **Technical and security information:** IP addresses, device and browser details, login activity, errors, safety-screening results, and model usage and allowance records. Necessary cookies and local storage keep users signed in and support app functions.
- **Optional newsletter:** email addresses of parents/carers or teachers who choose to receive updates, stored separately from research data.

We will obtain information directly from you or your child, through app use, questionnaires, and interviews.

We do not deliberately seek special category data, such as information about health, religion or ethnicity. Sensitive information may nevertheless appear in wellbeing answers, interviews, chats or files. Please avoid providing unnecessary personal information about yourself or anyone else.

4. How we use your personal data

We will only use personal data when the law allows us to. Most commonly, we will use your personal data in the following circumstances:

- recruit and contact participants, record permissions, arrange sessions, provide study accounts, and handle withdrawal requests;
- understand how AI affects young people's learning, choices and agency by comparing interviews, questionnaires, and app interaction logs over time;
- operate and improve the research app, investigate technical problems, and protect accounts and systems;
- check participants' wellbeing, identify possible safety concerns, and take appropriate safeguarding action;
- produce research findings summaries, presentations, and publications; and
- where you opt in, send the optional newsletter.

Privacy screening. Before chat text is saved by the app or sent to the AI model, it is sent to an AWS screening service to mask detected high-confidence identifiers, such as email addresses, telephone numbers, passwords, payment-card and bank details, and National Insurance or NHS numbers. This screening service receives the unmasked text. If screening fails, the message is not saved or sent to the model. Names, addresses, ages, places and other ambiguous details are not automatically removed. Checks can miss information.

Uploads are initially isolated for malware checks and screening of extracted text. Image text may be extracted by an AWS service. Uploads with detected prohibited identifiers or failed checks are rejected. These checks do not cover all document content: for example, text within images embedded in documents or scanned PDFs may not be checked, and files with no extractable text can pass.

AI processing. We use AI models through Amazon Bedrock with settings that do not retain model inputs and outputs or make them available to the model provider. Chats are not used to train AI models. The study itself still stores chats and research logs. The separate image-safety exception is described in section 5.

Safeguarding. Automated checks screen messages, extracted upload text and AI replies for harmful content. Replies are screened in chunks before display. High-confidence concerns can block content and trigger an email to designated safeguarding leads. Researchers can review the linked records and decide what action is needed. Other flags may be recorded for review without blocking.

If we believe someone is unsafe, we may share relevant information with a parent/carer, teacher, safeguarding worker or appropriate authority. Safeguarding records are held separately from research data. Automated checks can miss concerns or flag harmless content; people make safeguarding decisions. The app is available from 06:00 to 22:00 UK time during the study, but it is not an emergency service and records are not continuously monitored. A young person needing urgent help should tell a trusted adult.

We will share a summary of the findings with participants. Reports, presentations and publications may include carefully checked quotations and case descriptions. We remove or generalise identifying details and do not name participants, schools or youth organisations. Future sharing or reuse of a research dataset is subject to ethics approval and a review of the risk of identifying people.

Participation is voluntary. The app is a research prototype and may be refined during the study. It is not used to grade children or make solely automated decisions with legal or similarly significant effects about them.

Where the processing is based on your consent, you have the right to withdraw your consent at any time by contacting us using the details set out below. Please note that this will not affect the lawfulness of processing based on consent before its withdrawal.

5. Who we share your personal data with

Your personal data will be collected and processed primarily by our research team. Access is limited to people who need the information for the study or safeguarding. Authorised UCL and Oxford researchers can read research records, including app content and logs. The file linking names to study IDs is restricted to the UCL coordinating team and designated safeguarding leads. Oxford researchers work with records labelled by study ID, although interviewers will know the people they meet.

We may have to share your personal data with the parties set out below for the purposes outlined in section 4:

- **Amazon Web Services (AWS):** hosting the app, accounts, file storage, AI processing, screening, research and security logs, backups and safeguarding alert delivery.
- **Microsoft:** UCL Microsoft 365, Teams and OneDrive for interviews, transcription, communications, consent records and research files.
- **Qualtrics:** questionnaires and weekly check-ins under UCL's institutional licence. Responses use study IDs rather than names, although free text may still identify someone.

We require all third parties to respect the security of your personal data and to treat it in accordance with the law. We do not allow our third-party service providers to use your personal data for their own purposes – we only permit them to process your personal data for specified purposes and in accordance with our instructions. An exception applies to image safety screening: Amazon Web Services automatically check image inputs for any apparent child sexual abuse material. It may block, retain ,and review a flagged image and report it to the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children or another relevant authority. This cannot be switched off and is separate from the study's own safeguarding checks.
Parents and teachers will not receive general access to children's private chats. Any safeguarding disclosure is limited to what is needed. Other researchers or public repositories will receive a dataset only if it has been reviewed and is considered effectively anonymous for the intended sharing; removing names alone is insufficient, particularly in a small study.

6. **Lawful basis for processing**

Data Protection Legislation requires that we meet certain conditions before we are allowed to use your data in the manner described in this notice, including having a "lawful basis" for the processing under Article 6(1)(e) of the UK GDPR. The basis for processing will be as follows:

- **Consent** for the optional newsletter. You can withdraw that consent at any time by contacting the study team.
- **Public task** for the core study. The processing of your personal data is necessary to carry out this research, which is a task in the public interest. Agreement to take part is an ethical requirement, separate from this legal basis. We seek young people's assent and parental/carer consent, and separate consent from adult interviewees.

7. **International transfers**

App hosting and storage are mainly in AWS's London region. AI requests may be processed across EU regions through geographic cross-region inference, rather than only in London. Interview recordings and research files use UCL Microsoft services with UK storage arrangements.

Qualtrics processes and stores survey responses in the United States. UCL's arrangement relies on the UK Extension to the EU–US Data Protection Framework. Provider support or service telemetry may also involve overseas processing under institutional contracts and appropriate transfer safeguards, including standard contractual clauses and UK addenda where needed.

Amazon's image-safety reporting described in section 5 may involve a flagged image being sent to authorities outside the UK or European Economic Area. For more information about applicable transfer safeguards, contact UCL's Data Protection Officer.

8. **Information security**

We have put in place appropriate security measures to prevent your personal data from being accidentally lost, used or accessed in an unauthorised way, altered or disclosed. These include encryption during transfer and storage, individual accounts, restricted permissions, backups, access reviews and removal of access when no longer needed. We keep contact details separately from research data and use pseudonymous study IDs wherever possible.

Researchers create children's accounts; the app does not allow public self-registration. Account email addresses are study aliases rather than children's personal email addresses. Children set their own passwords. Uploaded files are delivered through the app's access checks.

We have established procedures to deal with any suspected personal data breach and will notify you and any applicable regulator of a breach where we are legally required to do so.

9. **Data retention**

We will only retain your personal data for as long as necessary to fulfil the purposes we collected it for, including for the purposes of satisfying any legal, accounting, or reporting requirements.

The main data retention periods are:

- **Names linked to study IDs:** each linking file entry is deleted two weeks after the participant's final session, or when withdrawal is actioned.
- **Interview audio:** deleted as soon as the transcript has been checked.
- **Study accounts, uploads, chats and research logs:** kept during the study unless withdrawn. Accounts are disabled at the end. Working copies and exports are deleted once the research archive is verified.
- **Research archive:** retained for at least 10 years after project completion. A reviewed, effectively anonymous copy shared for research may be kept indefinitely.
- **Consent and withdrawal evidence:** kept separately for 10 years after project completion, including the minimum information needed to show that a withdrawal was completed.
- **Technical records:** browser, diagnostic, network and firewall logs are normally kept for 30 days. Security audit records are kept for up to 365 days. Queued safeguarding alert copies expire within 14 days; delivered alerts are kept until withdrawal or study end, separately from research data.
- **Backups:** database backups roll over after 7 days and file-system backups after 35 days. Cache snapshots last 1 day. Final database snapshots are deleted after archive and closure checks, unless needed for an active recovery or incident.
- **Newsletter contacts:** kept until you opt out or the newsletter purpose ends.

10. **Your rights**

Under certain circumstances, you may have the following rights under data protection legislation in relation to your personal data:

- Right to request access to your personal data;
- Right to request correction of your personal data;
- Right to request erasure of your personal data;
- Right to object to processing of your personal data;
- Right to request restriction of the processing your personal data;
- Right to request the transfer of your personal data; and
- Right to withdraw consent.

If you wish to exercise any of these rights, please contact the Data Protection Officer.

Contacting us

For questions about the study or withdrawal, contact Prof. Manolis Mavrikis and the UCL team at learnwithai@ucl.ac.uk.

The Oxford team, led by Dr. Jun Zhao, can be contacted at oxfordccai@cs.ox.ac.uk.

For questions about this Privacy Notice or to exercise your legal rights, contact UCL's Data Protection & Freedom of Information Officer at data-protection@ucl.ac.uk.

You can also contact UCL by telephoning +44 (0)20 7679 2000 or by writing to: University College London, Gower Street, London WC1E 6BT.

11. **Complaints**

If you wish to complain about our use of personal data, please send an email with the details of your complaint to the Data Protection Officer so that we can look into the issue and respond to you.

You also have the right to lodge a complaint with the Information Commissioner's Office (ICO) (the UK data protection regulator). For further information on your rights and how to complain to the ICO, please refer to the ICO website.